egy to win the 2024 general election by consolidating the Hindu vote through cementing the narrative that Hindus are under threat from Muslims.

A few other historians, including Romila Thapar, Irfan Habib, Kumkum Roy, Mridula Mukherjee and Sucheta Mahajan, claim that the selective deletions on Mughals and Muslims expose the wider communal intent of the government, based on inaccurate assumptions about India's past. "In medieval times, the Mughal and the Vijayanagara were two of the most important empires in the Indian subcontinent, both of which were discussed in previous textbooks. In the revised version, while the chapter on the Mughals has been deleted, the chapter on the Vijayanagara Empire has been retained," read a statement issued by these historians. The Indian History Congress (IHC) has expressed deep concern over these omissions, saying that all those scholars who value "rational scientific knowledge" have found this approach flawed and unacceptable. Pointing towards the deletion of the chapter on Mughals, the IHC said that such a narrow communalistic approach to history was antithetical to the idea of a modern progressive society.

THE NCERT'S RATIONALE

The NCERT steadfastly denies any bias or political pressure to make these changes. Former NCERT director Hrushikesh Senapati, under whom two revisions of textbooks took place, in 2017 and 2019, claims that there was no political pressure on the agency. "We invited suggestions from all stakeholders, including teachers and students, and incorporated the changes in a transparent and democratic way. Of course, we consulted the minister also, as he is the president," says Senapati. NCERT director Saklani, a historian himself, says that the ongoing debate on the issue is unnecessary as the cuts are temporary and will not impact the learning process and knowledge of the students. "We are currently in a transition phase and working towards finalising the National Curriculum Framework (NCF) for school education. From next year, new textbooks under the revised NCF will start getting printed and the existing ones phased out," he says. Former director J.S. Rajput is in agreement. "Nobody can deny that Godse killed Gandhi. Nobody can remove Mughal history," he says. "All those who are making noises should wait for the new textbooks written under the new NCF."



"REPLACING HISTORY WITH A VERSION MORE SUITED TO ITS IDEOLOGY HAS LONG BEEN THE SANGH AGENDA. IT'S NO SURPRISE NCERT HAS DELETED REFERENCES WHERE RSS COULD BE IMPLICATED IN BAPU'S MURDER"

–TUSHAR GANDHI
Author and Gandhi's great-grandson

Saklani also dismisses the allegation that there is an attempt to erase Mughal history from textbooks. "Mughal history continues to be part of the curriculum in various classes," he says. "Students still study Mughal history in Classes 7, 11 and 12. Only one of the two chapters on Mughals in Class 12 has been deleted because the expert committee thought it was not significant," he says. Another assertion is that most of the deleted content from one textbook finds place in others. For instance, if references to castes and varnas have been removed in the social science textbook for Class 6, it is retained in the history textbook of Class 12 with details of Indian society as chronicled by Al-Biruni. The reference to Godse as "a Hindu extremist", too, has been retained in the history textbook for Class 12.

And if references to the 2002 Gujarat riots have been removed, Saklani points out, so also has the mention of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots from the Class 12 sociology textbook *Indian Society*. More importantly, big chunks on the Emergency of 1975 and abuse of power in this period by the Indira Gandhi government have also been removed from the political science and sociology textbooks for Class 12. "The expert committee suggested deletions based on what was not necessary or has already been repeated in other classes or books. That references to the Emergency have also been deleted means that the exercise was not bound by any political motive. References to Mughals or Emergency are not erased from every book, they can still be found in other chapters or classes," explains Saklani.

The NCERT director claims that the entire "rationalisation" exercise was done very professionally with the help of external experts who recommended that those chapters could be dropped without affecting the students' knowledge. Saklani, however, declined to name the external experts involved in the process, or the arguments on the basis of which these omissions were made. It was a response by the Union minister of state for education Annapurna Devi in the Lok Sabha that revealed the name of the experts. For the history books, the external experts included Umesh Kadam, professor of history at the Centre for Historical Studies, JNU, Archana Verma, associate professor of history at Hindu College, Delhi, and three postgraduate teachers from schools. Experts for the revision of the political science textbooks included Vanthangpui Khobung, assistant professor of political science